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Bernie Kirsh

Bernie Kirsh is a highly respected recording, mixing, and mastering engineer. Since his initial gig at Electric Lady Studios in the mid-70s, Bernie has collaborated with a long list of successful artists, most notably his 45-year association with Chick Corea.

Bernie was interviewed via Zoom on August 27, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: And let me just see if the tape is rolling.

BK: Okay, that's right. You know it's funny, we're still saying "rolling." You know it's still the term. Nothing is rolling, but —

MR: Are you out of film yet?

BK: Yeah, that's right.

MR: So I'm pleased to be talking to Bernie Kirsh today, my name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. And congratulations on your career.

BK: Thank you, thank you, yeah, I appreciate that.

MR: I know a lot of engineers and people who would be envious of what you've done.

BK: Oh well that's nice to know that people have that kind of regard. You know for yourself and others who do things, you know you just do them. And so not much more than that, really.

MR: That's fairly eloquent I think.

BK: Well it's true. It's true.

MR: Yeah. You just do them. And I'm going to ask you a little bit about that but I wanted to start with a little scenario. You and I are fairly close together in age and I was looking at the top songs of 1966 and I was thinking of you, if my stats are correct you were mid-way through college around then?

BK: Yeah, '66 I was, yeah, that's right. Mid-way through college. Yeah.

MR: Yeah. And the playlist top songs of that year included everyone from the Mamas and the Papas, The Beatles, Ray Conniff, The Monkees, and Frank Sinatra. So were you a person who listened to music by this point, noticing things that the average listener did not?

BK: I don't know. I don't know what the average listener is listening to, but I mean my interest was not listening for anything in particular, it was just enjoying the music. I started out as a musician playing, you know, through I guess grade school, junior high school, started playing brass instruments, trombone, baritone horn, that sort of thing. Always had an interest in my life that I never really fulfilled totally to my liking of keyboard/piano playing. But the brass instruments, and the trombone in particular, were

my way into a musical life and that consisted of all of the things you do in school, in high school, and around them. I grew up in Philadelphia, which had a great music program by the way. There were some wonderful people there and a great curriculum. And in high school you get theory of harmony, counterpoint, composition — in high school. And they had the All-City programs. So my interest was in playing music. I enjoyed it.

MR: I'm going to pause for a second. I'm not pausing, but I'm getting a sort of a hiss every time you speak. Do you know what that might be?

BK: You know what? I think it's the fan in this. I don't know.

MR: I think that's probably correct.

BK: Yeah 'cause I can hear the fan going. I'm not sure.

MR: Oh it's the fan in the computer?

BK: In the computer. It's a laptop. Yeah.

MR: Okay. It's not bad. I have a guy who can maybe do some tweaking.

BK: Okay.

MR: Yeah. But at some point did you start hearing ways of recording music that you noticed and then what made you enter this world?

BK: Happenstance. I had no interest — well back up a little bit. When I was in college I actually turned into a theater major and got involved in technical theater, did all the other things that a theater student would do — acting, directing, and so forth. But then got an offer for a graduate assistantship in technical theater: building sets and that sort of thing. So I went to graduate school doing that and while I was there I got involved in the television station at the school. And of course I had my theater background and I understood, started to understand lighting and all those aspects. Sound was always the poor cousin. It never got its due. So I really didn't have much attention on sound, and no interest in it really. But then after college, after grad school I went to New York to want to work in television. So I'm staying with a friend in an apartment in Greenwich Village on Bleecker Street and right down the street was The Bitter End, which was a mainstream club in those days. This was 1970. And it was there that I heard there was an opening from somebody, for doing the lights and sound. And I knew about lighting. Didn't know anything about sound. So I took the job and did that for about a year or so. And there would be recordings that would go on there. Live recordings. Curtis Mayfield, all these great artists just coming through there. I mean there would be Carly Simon opening for Kris Kristofferson, you know it was that era, but major acts. So the people who would come in to record were of some experience and they would park a truck outside. So one day an engineer came in who was doing the recording and we started talking and this and that, and he mentioned that Jimi Hendrix had opened up a studio around the corner and that's where he was working. And I said, "Oh can I come watch?" Be kind of interesting

you know. And so I went over there every day for a couple of weeks. I was working nights of course, at the club, and during the day I would just go over there and spend hours just sitting in the back of the room watching what was going on, and got interested. I got interested in the process, in working with musicians, which I had been doing at the club, but I love musicians. And you know it's my group, my people. And so it was a way for me to interact with them. I wasn't playing anymore, I really wasn't playing the horn anymore, I was really involved more in the service activities around music.

MR: Can you recall what kind of recording deck, or what did the booth look like when you first worked there?

BK: Oh yes, very good. It was — At the time I was back in Studio B and it had a Datamix console which — I don't think there were a lot of them. I think Atlantic had one or two, and Eddie Kramer, who was the founding engineer at the studio, he of course most famous for his work with Jimi Hendrix, and did so many of his recordings. And it was Jimi's studio. So Eddie would stipulate what the equipment would be and he worked with a great technical staff, a guy named Shimon Ron who was a big help in putting that place together and so forth. And there were other guys around, a wonderful, wonderful engineer, a guy named Dave Palmer who worked with Eddie, he was his first assistant. So there were a lot of people there, and it was outfitted very well. We had — they were still doing 8 track recording, of course 4 track in stereo and mono, but the track count at that point was really a — 16 was just in at that point; 24 track recording hadn't occurred yet. So you had an MM1000 — basically it was a video desk, an Ampex video desk that they converted to be able to record analog audio. And there would be a 4 track recorder and stereo recorders, and that was the room, aside from the microphones.

MR: And two inch tape? Was that —

BK: Yeah, two inch tape, yeah. The 8 track of course was one inch tape but the 16 track was two inch tape. It sounded great. It was a chunky sound.

MR: I can remember the first time I saw that kind of thing it was like whoa, look at all this stuff.

BK: Yeah I know. Well it hit me like that too. I loved it. It was just, I don't know, it seemed very real to me. It seemed, it was a way to do something substantial. The quality was high. And I saw an opportunity to have fun and create valuable product with someone else, with musicians. And I loved it. It was great.

MR: Did they give you like okay Bernie, go wrap up these cords, go solder this thing, or you know move the drums around, that kind of task?

BK: Well there was a lot of that, not much soldering but there was a lot of moving and winding up and setting up and tearing down and do this and do that. You know it was an apprenticeship, it doesn't really occur these days, but I mean truthfully my concept of

input and output, one going — you know a microphone is input and a speaker is output. Or if you go to a patch bay how do you route a signal, what is in and out, what was a new concept for me, really, in terms of really understanding the basics of audio. And I got it through just doing and making mistakes. So that was my life.

MR: How many mistakes did you make?

BK: Well a lot. And in that working, I don't know, two, three hundred hours a week in the studio and you're just there all the time and session after session all kinds of different people. There were the house engineers who were doing the dates that people would come to the studio for and it was the beginnings of guest engineers, you know, independent engineers who were coming in to use the studio and would come in with a client, with an artist. So there were a lot of those and a lot of great opportunity to sit and watch these masters do what they were doing. So that was what was going on.

MR: Do you recall the first time you were asked to splice tape?

BK: I do. Yeah actually, yeah. It was an 8 track recording, I think it was Paul Winter I think was the artist actually. And I was assisting on the date. And the engineer said, "Yeah put that together." You know like that. "Put some splicing tape, and put that together." And I thought oh man. So, and you do it. You do it, like any other craft you just learn how to do it.

MR: You observe and listen and then —

BK: And practice.

MR: Yeah. I don't think I'd want to practice on a real date you know, but —

BK: You know it's funny, those were the techniques in those days, so you didn't think much about it. I mean subsequently there would be edits that I would attempt to do, and hopefully successfully, that required, you know, slices of a piece of tape. And you might have three or four different tries at it that were all sliced and you'd have to get them in order on the backing with the tape backing so they would play correctly. Because if it didn't play then you just destroyed something. So you learned these editing techniques. It's a little easier today with Pro Tools and Logic Audio, a little less nerves going on.

MR: Am I correct that you recorded Patti Smith's "Horses" record?

BK: Yeah I did, I did. That was 1975, fall of '75 I think, October, somewhere in there.

MR: Do you remember what you thought about it at the time? I guess it's as simple asking did you like it?

BK: I did. I enjoyed her creativity. You know it was, you know just to give you a little background going into that, because this is now five years, four years after I started working at Electric Lady and working as an engineer, I had done a lot of stuff just sitting and watching. The first session I was on observing was Stevie Wonder. I mean this is the kind of stuff that was going on there. And great engineers, Bob Margouleff and Malcolm

Cecil, the two guys that were recording and producing Stevie at the time. And I got to sit and watch these guys and they were developing — they were using Moog synthesizers and they had a one called TONTO was the name, and it was these three huge panels of Moog equipment and so forth, and they would work overnight to create a bass sound or whatever they were doing. So there was that, and then another date comes in and it's John McLaughlin and the Mahavishnu Orchestra. That's when my life changed. And I was in the studio setting up, Billy Cobham was the drummer and I was setting up his mics on the drums. And the door opens and John walks in and looking great. I mean up until this point most of what I'd seen were rock groups of the era, that sort of thing. And John came in in a different level of competence and aesthetic. And really all these guys were, they were just great musicians. And I took note of that. I thought you know this is an aesthetic that I really like. This is a high level of communication and competences as players and people were liking it. It was a wide audience and they were trying new things, as were other people coming off the Miles Davis experience at the time, the jazz fusion. And so that kind of locked me in. That was like '72, '73 whenever that was.

MR: Yeah, I must insert that I was living in Buffalo at the time and someone gave me tickets to see The Mahavishnu Orchestra, and I didn't know what or who they were, and wow. I was totally blown away by that.

BK: Yeah it wasn't just precision and it wasn't just technical expertise it was using that to create beautiful communication and interplay between the guys and it was at a high level. So anyway so I enjoyed that, and so I was in that mindset and was still doing you know rock dates and then the next thing that happens is in '74 Stanley Clarke comes in to do his recording, do an album. I think it was his second album. And so I did some assisting on that and the engineer, Ken Scott, a great engineer, said, "Listen I can't make it tomorrow night. Why don't you record this for me, and I'll mix it, but if you'll record it for me that'd be great. It's just a trio." And I said okay, it's just bass, guitar and piano. And I go in and I set it up the way I thought it should be set up and in comes John McLaughlin, who I'd worked with before, and he was playing acoustic guitar, and Chick Corea comes in. So it was the three guys, and that's when I met these characters as a group. And it was a beautiful, beautiful session. It was called "Song to John" was the name of it, a piece that Stanley had written. I think it's in two parts. And so that was my introduction to Chick and then I didn't see him for another I would say better part of a year. Prior to seeing him again I was interviewed to do an album for Patti Smith. She wanted to work at Electric Lady, for the vibe, you know because it was Jimi's place and so forth. So I went and talked to her and we worked it out and I started doing the recording, and did it, and enjoyed her style. She was really a poet and that was her — I think her main impetus, I mean she enjoyed the music and so forth. That's my view, not hers, of what she was

doing. And she was expressing her music via her sense of poetry and so forth, and she was working with some other musicians. But it was basically rock. It was the beginnings of punk rock. So it wasn't something that I had been digesting at all. It was something new for me. But I got into the game of it and I was just having fun. It was just fun.

MR: Did you ever have to go out into the main room and tell a guitar player, say, listen I can't record you at that volume? Because I was listening to the title track and it reminded me of some of the some that I've been a part of in a studio here in Central New York, and I found this quote from *Rolling Stone*, they were talking about the date that we're discussing and the band part of it. And this reviewer said, "The instrumental music is the kind of artful rock & roll primitism that has long characterized the New York underground."

BK: Interesting.

MR: Did you know that at the time?

BK: I know things were going on in the underground but I wasn't fully aware. There were CBGBs there and there was another place on the east side that was — I've forgotten the name of it now but yeah.

MR: Well the record's become quite a historical marker I think, it's part of the National Recording Registry for significant historical and cultural event. So it's nice —

BK: Yeah it just became a Grammy Hall of Fame winner as well — not winner, that's the wrong term, I guess it's now part of that. Yeah.

MR: So then comes "Leprechaun" is that right?

BK: Just after that is the "Leprechaun." Now we're talking from October to December. So I did that album and then started the "Leprechaun" in December of that year, '75. Late '75. And that was another major shift in influence and path of my life, going into that and working with Chick. And we hit it off really — I didn't really get to know him much during the previous recording, I just did my job and that sort of thing. But now we were working together on a longer basis and I got to know him and we did this project together and it just fit like a glove. I knew exactly what he wanted to hear. Because I was hearing it myself. It was just easy communication.

MR: Could you be more maybe specific about what he wanted to hear and what you heard also?

BK: Well I mean he would play, you know, there are two types of things that were going on. There was a roomful of musicians which is one scenario. And they would be building a song, which was another scenario, which would be an overdubbing scenario where he would use synths and percussion and that sort of thing. The opening piece of that is like that. There's just — it's just creative fun, it's just sounds and music. And when I heard it there was nothing to do except to make things in relationship to others in terms of volume

and panning and treatment other than what I wanted to hear, and what I wanted to hear from the different parts that were coming in were things that he agreed with. So there was that kind of reality that went on and that really continued for the course of the project.

MR: Did they record most of that music with a click track?

BK: Not at all. That was Steve Gadd.

MR: So they had a click track. All right.

BK: I mean that album, if you could, there are three components that go through that album. One is Chick, one is Steve Gadd, and the other is Gayle Moran, her vocals, all the way through. But in terms of the basic track, not the vocals of course which added so much, but just the instrumentation. There's a lot going on but basically Chick and Steve are the — it's almost like a duet album in a sense. If you listen to that relationship it's just amazing for that. So there was no click track, no.

MR: Okay.

BK: And I'll tell you, when you deal with Chick and you deal with Steve you don't need any click.

MR: As an engineer to go from Patti Smith to that "Leprechaun" it seems to me to be quite a leap because you had to record strings and woodwinds and vocals, so —

BK: Yeah well they were all live in the room too. I mean it was all in one room. We had — I had the string quartet in one area, the horns in another, the rhythm section, two bass players, you know, piano and Gayle's in the booth singing. So there's a lot of activity which added to fun factor the minute it went out the roof, having all those musicians on the room.

MR: Did the room have a distinct sound itself?

BK: I don't know that it did. I think it allowed for what was recorded in there to sound pleasant and musical. You know you wouldn't get sounds occurring in another part of the room that weren't favorable coming in. The room was set up nicely acoustically. John Storyk was the architect and I think it was his first studio by the way too. I think. I may be wrong, but I think so. And anyway so we have a roomful of musicians and you know we have Steve Gadd sitting in, it wasn't a drum booth but it was like a partition that went around the drums and he had three or four music stands in front of him with the music strewn like this and he'd be reading the music and playing. And it was just that. It was just a busy scene of competence showing itself off.

MR: And Chick arranged all that music himself?

BK: He did, yeah. And great musicians. So that was — and that project was exactly what I understood. I understood from a mixer's point of view what that music was. It was just very real to me. I didn't have — nothing to think about. I could just set up things and do what I needed to do to get the final result. So it wasn't a lot of trial and error going on. It

was, oh I heard that and I'd try to accomplish that, and it just went on. I mean of course with Chick's music you can't go far afield anyway from anything that sounds great because what you're working with lends itself easily to enjoyment. I don't think you can mess it up too much.

MR: Were the mixes done with just Chick and yourself?

BK: Yeah. Just hands on the faders. You know there was no automation in those days.

MR: Oh right. Hands on faders. Yeah.

BK: Hands on faders. So you know mostly it would just be he would, I guess from time to time he would come in and handle something but mostly it was just my own figuring it out, how to accomplish it. I mean it was recorded in a way that it wasn't a lot of crazy moves to do and that sort of thing. But what we did have of course were, you only have a certain amount of tracks. So if you're doing overdubs you have to share tracks with something that's already recorded on one portion. So you'd have maybe — not that this was the case — but let's say you had I don't know a keyboard playing on the verses but not on the choruses. So you could use the choruses for something else. So you'd record another instrument on that track in the space where you had the chorus. And you know then you'd have to deal with that fader.

MR: Isn't that interesting because now we think — oh how primitive.

BK: Well yeah it's true.

MR: But at the time that's — you worked with what you had. I can recall that exact scenario, overdubbing a part on a track that had things in it and I would watch the engineer and he would like — "boop boop" in and out.

BK: Oh punch in and out. Right.

MR: Punch in and out for sometimes two notes or something like that.

BK: Yeah. Another potential destructive activity. Yeah. But tape recorders got, you know in the early — originally there was a delay between — because you have an erase head, a record head, and a play head. There were three heads. And they were in that order: erase, record, play. So the way they developed tape recorders, that record head also had the capability to play back for the other tracks that weren't being recorded on. So that was called the sync head. But there was a slight distance between the erase head and the record/sync head. So you'd have to anticipate your punch to allow for that time lag. So anyway it got interesting.

MR: How many years was it from then that you made the transition to completely digital?

BK: Well digital didn't happen until the 90s. We're talking you know 25 years. Well no, actually mid-80s I guess digital started really happening. I did my first digital project, recorded two digital — I think it was in '83. So but Pro Tools and those sort of things didn't develop until the next decade.

MR: Was it a steep learning curve for you?

BK: Well it happened on a gradient. So yeah I mean going to the digital audio workstations like Pro Tools and Logic Audio, that was a steeper gradient. Because all of a sudden I was in a project where I had to do it. So I picked up, I would call people I would pick up any data I could and just went in and tried it. And got on the phone if I ran into trouble.

MR: Some audiophiles, especially before the improvement of digital recordings, would insist that analog has really got the warmer sound and where do you come down? Is that a debate for you or do you notice any difference?

BK: You mean in present time?

MR: Back when it sort of started transitioning. Could you hear, was there any harshness or just like something sounds awry here.

BK: I would say yes, yeah. I remember one time there was a symposium, I think SONY was sponsoring it at Ocean Wave Studios. And they had, they were showing off their CD stuff and they had LPs and they had CDs and — of the same project. And they would put on the CD and you'd play the LP and the LP went around and round and then they took — I don't know why they did this, they took the LP and they put it on the floor and scuffed it or something and it came back sounding funny, but they picked up the CD and they weren't as harsh with it, it kind of did something and it played well. Or something like that. And the truth of the matter was even though the LP had noises, the sound was better. The underlying sound was still better. So it didn't really speak to quality, it spoke to some other quality. You know, not good sounding stuff. So that went on. And then the debate went on and on and I was on the analog side all the way. But then we started doing analog recording but digital masters. That was the next gradient. And then GRP came in and that was what was their thing, a digital master company. So their projects were delivered as digital products and then it continued from there.

MR: I remember being surprised in the recordings, the thing is finally mixed, it's done, and then I learned that, not quite, it has to be mastered.

BK: Yeah, that's right.

MR: And I still am not totally sure what exactly that means but someone could potentially mess up a product by not mastering it correctly.

BK: That's the case. Usually they enhance it, is what usually happens I think. That's what I found. If you go to the right people.

MR: Did you have right people for yourself, like please send it here, don't send it there?

BK: Yeah. I've used a number of different mastering places over the years. The one that I tend to stay with is a guy named Bernie Grundman in Los Angeles. Bernie Grundman Mastering. And he's a master. All the equipment is tweaked and so forth. You know if you're mixing in different environments you can — you're making a determination as

you do by listening and you go okay that sounds good. But how does it compare to other things and is the room accurate and — I think a mastering facility, especially one like that where all kinds of project comes through, becomes a touchstone for what might be considered a reference, a good reference as to what to make changes from . So that's — there are other technical parts of it as well, in terms of the equipment it goes through before it goes to the plants for manufacturing, but there are lots of things that they can do to alter the audio in a way that may enhance it. Because if you do it wrong it doesn't enhance it but usually it does.

MR: Did you ever think about the fact that you're going to all this technical expertise and putting your heart and soul into a product and then it goes out in the marketplace and people maybe playing it on two inch speakers, either coming out of their computer now or ear buds. Can you anticipate the way it's being played when you record it?

BK: You really can't. I mean you can listen to it in those different formats, different speakers and so forth but you find a reference for yourself and you go by that. You've got to please your own aesthetic and then compare it in the world to make sure that it's conveying properly through whatever other means. Yeah. Because the variations are endless, different amplifiers, different pre amps, different speakers, different rooms, different cars. You know whatever.

MR: I can remember listening in the 60s with a transistor radio where you had one ear plug.

BK: Oh right, right. Mono.

MR: Luckily it was mono. So you apparently passed Chick's audition with "Leprechaun." Did he officially in some fashion say you're going to be my guy?

BK: No not really. I mean we did that recording and then he called me up for the next project basically, which was "My Spanish Heart" which was the next album, and went out to Los Angeles to do that. And it was just taking it a day at a time with that and what I was doing was still in New York working. And then I got the idea — oh on the next project we did, we did the last "Return to Forever" album called "Music Magic" out in Colorado. And it was just after that I thought you know what? I think I'm going to move to — well no I went on the road with him at that point. I became his concert sound mixer at that point, after that project. That was in '77. And it was that experience, getting to know everybody, all the people around him and so forth, touring, as you know, creates a special bond, a camaraderie. And I decided to move to California. And then I was just still working project to project. I really was kind of quote a staff member just for a very short period of time, not much at all. Basically I was an independent guy all these years, associated strongly but not necessarily a salaried person.

MR: How do you charge for your expertise? Is there a recording engineer's union?

BK: No I think you find out what people are getting and see if you can too.

MR: I see.

BK: Yeah. But you know Chick's influence in my life was just huge. I mean he's a guy who was a beautiful guy, just a beautiful guy. What you hear in his music is him. That's his — the spirit of Chick is what you're hearing and that's how he was as a person. He was just beautiful, beautiful guy. And very kind of a generous guy. You know when you're on the bandstand with somebody all of the social mechanisms that people employ in daily social interaction go away. You're just there with another player playing the music and so you can get a feel for somebody that way. You know? Because you're really dealing — it's a spiritual activity, music. I mean you're hearing it out of speakers and that's the result of what had occurred before. But in the creative process, you know, you're talking about someone's decision to create beauty with somebody else. And the interplay of that is the heart of it. It's why it happens. I mean there may be all kinds of other products that occur as a result of it, but that's the essence of it, that relationship and in relationship eventually to the audience in a live situation where things are created in a live way. And Chick was a communicator of the highest level. Not only in his music but in life generally. That was one of his abilities. And so I think you find people who knew Chick would all agree that — I hear the same things over and over again, you know he lets people create. You know it's basically allowing people to do what they do and grant them enough life to accept what they're saying and not to put any negative aspect on it. That's just what somebody else said, musically. And so you can like it or not like it but you don't have to invalidate what the guy did. 'Cause that's invalidating him. And that's something that it seemed to me that he didn't — that I didn't see him do. You know he would handle those things in another way than directly imposing something on someone's artistry.

MR: I see. This might be a good moment to read something, an excerpt from what you said about Chick. This is from May of 2021: "Yes he was a genius but that's not enough of a descriptive word of all he was. He was generous as a musician as well as a person, and his love and support for other artists is unsurpassed. He loved to play with other musicians and when he did he did all he could to help musicians realize their most dear and personal artistic desires. It was just as important to see the others create with great satisfaction, as it was for him."

BK: Yeah. Well that's basically it. Thanks for doing that, it saved me some words. I already said it.

MR: Oh it's lovely and it caught my attention and it came from this, which we'll talk about soon. That's wonderful. I wondered what being on the road with Chick is like. You get in a venue and go okay what do we have today?

BK: Well of course they were all different — each one has its — they all have the same components it's just different problems to solve. You know because I'm coming at it

from a technical point of view when I walk into the venue, sound-wise. Things have to be set up and connected and all that kind of stuff. Get ready for the sound check is basically it, and that's when the musicians show up. But yeah, they all have their own problems. I really enjoyed the live sound mixing that I did with Chick. It was — there was nothing to think about. Just — they played on stage and I got to make it sound the way I liked it to sound. It was a real playground.

MR: You have had a great gig.

BK: Yeah, yeah, it's true.

MR: You know one thing about Chick that he seemed to have a very distinctive sound on the Fender Rhodes and I wonder if you had anything to do with that?

BK: No that was — I mean I recorded it — it depends which era you're talking about. I mean he got into the Fender Rhodes early, before Bernie, but actually from Miles — Miles or shortly after Miles and liked it. I'm thinking originally he didn't like it. I think he didn't care for it and I think he wanted to play the piano. But then later on he definitely adopted it. In "Return to Forever" it's in full force, you know that's in full force. So it was a sound he'd already developed. He had different versions of it. There would be a kind of a distorted sound that he would get sometimes when he'd hit hard and he had delays and those sorts of things on it. But that came out of his interest in having the instrument sound.

MR: Is there a Bernie Kirsh method of recording a Steinway Grand?

BK: Well, you know yeah I guess you've got to figure out, usually I mean you can use more than two, I usually just use two mics and put them in an area that I find apropos to the music we're going to be recording. And then go in and listen and handle things, maybe adjust things. I mean there's no tricks. I mean you just put the microphones there and go maybe I should move — am I hearing the left hand far enough to the left? I'll move the mic. Let's see does the piano sound like it's leaning this way? Oh I see. And just listening and changing.

MR: Does it sound like it's leaning this way?

BK: Yeah. Because if the right hand of the piano — if you're listening in a stereo image if the right hand of the piano is now moving, sounding like it's moving toward the center although the note seems to be up further that way on the piano, then to me it's leaning.

MR: I like that. I'm picturing today's hopeful engineer who goes to a four year school to get a degree and I wonder if anybody ever says that to them?

BK: Yeah, I don't know. Good question. I think it just comes out of — you know you record it and you have an idea of what you want it to sound like and if it doesn't sound like that it's leaning I guess.

MR: Are you protective of your hearing?

BK: Somewhat. Not — I try not to listen too loud. I mean I had my hearing checked a little over a year ago I guess, within the last couple of years and there was some high end loss, not much you know. So it's still doing pretty good. But yeah. You know I'll — if there's loud sounds — I did a "Return to Forever" tour which can get kind of loud. I put things in my ears.

MR: Did Chick's devotion to Scientology come to work with him?

BK: In what respect do you mean?

MR: Did you get the feeling that decisions he made were based on his belief in Scientology?

BK: Well I can't imagine that the things that people know to be true for themselves wouldn't be expressed by them. I think that's probably true for anything. If you have a certain idea of how things are in the world and how you treat others then you would treat them that way and so forth. Is that what you mean? That sort of thing?

MR: I guess so. It was not a well formed question but I was sort of curious about what role it played in his musical life?

BK: It's hard for me to say. I mean because when you're hearing music coming you're hearing the whole thing you know? I can't imagine that there wasn't some influence in his understanding of the world for sure, but the music comes from his soul. You know it doesn't come from — there's not something else that is his music. You know it's something that he's decided he wanted to make. How he lives his life and how he sees the world that may be influenced by philosophy and so forth. But the creative process is a process that's the most personal thing you can do. It's the nearest thing to not being in this world that you can do. I mean I don't know, I mean I don't know if you've had the experience. I have, where the world goes away and you're just creating. So — and I think that's what occurs because it's coming from that place and that place is not in this world.

MR: He must have sensed that musical brotherhood in you.

BK: I suppose. I mean I think musical brotherhood may be a way to look at it, I think brotherhood is probably more apropos. I think we just hooked up through the process of doing these things together. That was the conduit for the hook-up but the result was that there was a bond there just like you have a friend. It's just a friend. And I was fortunate, extremely fortunate enough that it was with Chick. It certainly enriched my life. And I was able to contribute to enriching other people's lives in doing for Chick what I did and delivering it in a way that I felt was the most aesthetic and communicative way. Because he's making the communication. My job was to deliver it as beautifully as possible. And when you were doing it live you've got an audience there right away. There's no lag, it's not a recording. You're dealing with it right there. So I could see the results. Anyway it was, I don't know what I could say, it was a pleasure and a privilege.

MR: I'm glad you were around.

BK: Yeah, me too.

MR: You can't see it, but in front of my wall I printed out the Bernie Kirsh discography. And it numbers 86 — I don't know how correct that is. And I'm wondering, on the independent things you did besides Chick, what your —

BK: What's that number?

MR: 86 recordings. No 84.

BK: With Chick you mean?

MR: No. Starting with "Journey to Love" Stanley Clarke is the second one. It's sort of in order.

BK: Where did you cull these from?

MR: I got it off the internet somewhere. I'll send you the link and you can see what you've done. But I was curious about your relationships to various producers. Like going back to John Cale with Patti Smith and did you find it was different if a producer had been an engineer? Or if they had just not done that part of it?

BK: Well the only thing is they could speak in more technical terms I guess if they had been engineers. You know, I mean John wasn't an engineer, he was a string player. But yeah during that project I guess he had to leave the project at some point and I had to go in and take it over basically. It was just Patti and I at that point to bring it up through the mixing. So that was interesting. But he was an interesting guy, Velvet Underground and all that stuff. But technically I don't think — that wasn't his forte.

MR: Did you ever have to try and tell a producer that I don't think you want to do that?

BK: Well it depends on what the situation is. I mean I could have a difference of opinion about something and I would approach it in a way that wouldn't be encroaching, you know, the task is probably a greater amount of personal interaction — how shall I say — how to work with others, and how to keep things on an even keel in the control room and so forth, as much as it is a technical activity.

MR: I wanted to speak about this project that you've been involved with with Glenn Zottola. It's wonderful that Chick's legacy is continuing. And some of these recordings are really marvelous and it's nice that Glenn was there when Chick wanted to reach out. And apparently Chick would call him up very late and say, "What are you doing? Come on over."

BK: Yeah I know that was him. It's playing, just total playing. And they would do that. Yeah I mean they play great — Glenn is just a marvelous musician, just incredible. And he and Chick got along so well that way. And you can hear it in that recording. So great camaraderie there.

MR: It's like you said right at the beginning of our interview, you just did it. Just let it happen.

BK: Yeah you just go take a walk, put your foot out, take the next step. Well you know there's also the decision to like you make an objective, you create some sort of game you want to play. That's how you do stuff. You postulate something to do or to be, and you go well maybe if I go in this direction I will accomplish that. So I think that's all you do with whatever it is. Speaking about Glenn and this project, yeah, I know that he was very proud of his friendship and musical relationship with Chick and you know they had a really special musical bond. And he held Chick, and still does, in a high regard.

MR: Indeed. It looks like it's doing well with streams and so forth.

BK: Streams, right. Yeah. The new world.

MR: Whoever knew that we would use the word "stream" in regards to music.

BK: Yes. I mean streaming, streaming, streaming — musicians still aren't getting paid. You know?

MR: What is your general — to sort of wrap up — do you have a general opinion about the music industry the way it's recorded, the way it's delivered, the way it's not paid for? Or just things in general?

BK: Well the music business has changed. It's become a real decentralized — in terms of recording of course, it's decentralized. And there's good and bad. I mean what you have now is the ability of any artist to create recordings that he would like to do, any projects he would like to do because in your own home you have a recording studio. So that part is good. The difficult part is getting people to hear it. And in that respect streaming services are a definite advantage to getting works out. You know there are probably, of course the record company which is a marketing arm to use. But if you can't actually work with a record company then streaming is an outlet, aside from direct marketing, that you want to do on your own. I don't know how much musicians want to do that and so forth. So I'm not sure, you mean in terms of direction?

MR: The way that music is created and delivered I think you pretty much answered my question.

BK: Okay. Yeah I know, it's a different time. In some ways better. I always enjoy a roomful of musicians, people having fun and just making something together. So that's my vote.

MR: If you were doing a twelve hour session and you finally got home what do you like to hear afterwards?

BK: You know I don't know that I hear anything except my pillow. I think that that's where I go. I don't put on — I mean if I'm sitting and working I'll put on music and — if I'm doing administrative stuff I'll do that. But you know it's interesting you say that. I don't sit — I do from time to time but not like I used to where I would sit and put an album on and just sit on the sofa and just listen to the whole album through. It seems to be a little more piecemeal these days. I don't know, how do you find it?

MR: Same. Exactly the same. Yeah. I mean I play music a lot for a living so I don't necessarily listen to music as much as a lot of people would.

BK: Well probably the same for me. But yeah.

MR: I've loved this conversation and I'm going to wrap up with name this Chick Corea tune.

BK: Uh oh.

MR: And you'll have to excuse my delivery.

[scats]

BK: "One Step."

MR: Yay you got it. This is one of my favorite Chick Corea records.

BK: That's a beautiful record. Yeah. I know.

MR: And I don't know who made the decision but I thought it was a spot-on to put that as the first cut, side one.

BK: That was Chick.

MR: It's just like inviting.

BK: I agree. Yeah I love that. And the "Friends" cut is a favorite of mine too, that piece as well. So there's a lot of good stuff on it. Anyway good. You sing great!

MR: I'm going to put that on my resume that you said that.

BK: Okay.

MR: Well I appreciate your time and as I said I'm envious, not envious, I'm happy for your career and as you said all the things you've helped deliver to millions of listeners.

BK: Yeah well I mean things are not over yet but it's certainly up until this point been a very fulfilling, adventurous life.

MR: What's your next thing?

BK: Well we've got, you know still trying to keep an eye on Chick's legacy. So we've got a new Electric Band album that's coming out, a new live album that's coming out. We've got another, it's kind of a quasi-classical — not classical, well sort of classical jazz you know kind of thing that was recorded live in Europe. And just various projects —a vault of — I mean I would record every show, multi-track. So there's a lot to choose from plus there's stuff that's never seen the light of day so hopefully they will and just keep Chick's music coming out and helping people live a better life.

MR: I can't think of a better way to wrap up. Thanks a lot, Bernie.

BK: Yeah, my pleasure. Good talking with you.

MR: I'll just pause this and then we'll have our good-byes.

BK: Okay.

MR: All right. We're out.